

BLOCK 3
REPORTING BEATS-1



UNIT 7 CIVIC REPORTING

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7.0 INTRODUCTION

India being a democratic country, gives right to freedom of speech and expression to its citizens. Here civic journalism, also known as public journalism, is the idea of incorporating journalism into the democratic process. The media, famously known as the fourth pillar of democracy, has a responsibility to not just inform the public but to also involve the citizens in the process of framing public opinions through debates and group discussions etc. The new trend of journalism and democracy not only challenge together the orthodoxy arguments of traditional reporting, but also open up a new frontier for an alternative. It approaches with more optimistic evaluation of the contemporary public sphere and its contribution to the social and political process.

In this unit, we shall discuss this new trend of democratic journalism. ‘Civic or Public Journalism’ is a fresh trend, with an expression of public opinion. Civic journalism is the idea of integrating journalism into the democratic process which is why it is also known as public journalism. It is worth mentioning here that the new media plays a greater role in motivating civic journalism as it not only informs the public, but also works towards engaging citizens and creating public information forum or debate. The civic reporting therefore is an attempt to unrestraint the belief that journalists and their audiences are only spectators in political and social processes. In fact, the civic journalism treats readers as participants. In the contemporary scenario, civic journalism has become more of a philosophy rather than being just a practice. Civic Journalism is “a fundamental change in the way of modern media business”.

7.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you will be able to:

- discuss civic journalism and its use;
- understand the strengths and limitations of civic journalism as a media tool;
- explain the developments of civic journalism;
- describe the various aspects of civic journalism; and
- analyze the effect of civic journalism.

7.2 CIVIC JOURNALISM: AN EMERGING TREND IN REPORTING

Civic or public journalism a form of journalism that seeks to listen systematically to the stories and ideas of citizens even while protecting its freedom to choose whatever it wants to cover. It is an alternative way to frame stories on important community issues, and the best chance to inspire citizen deliberation and build public understanding of issues.

The conventional concept of journalism is gathering, assessing, creating news and information and disseminating the information to all. Journalism has diverse characteristics and practices. The new or modern media has brought a profound change in the interpretation of journalism. Civic journalism is an effort to reach out to the public more aggressively in the reporting process, to listen to how citizens frame their problems and what citizens see as solutions to those problems. Then, the other mainstream journalist can use that information to enrich news stories. Civic journalism is practiced by newspapers, radio and television stations in many developed countries around the world.

Decades later Dewey's argument was further explored by Jay Rosen and Davis Merritt, who were looking at the importance of the media in the democratic process. In 1993, Rosen and Merritt formed the concept of public journalism. In their joint "manifesto" on public journalism that was published in 1994, Rosen explained, "public journalism tried to place the journalist within the political community as a responsible member with a full stake in public life." But it does not deny the important difference between journalists and citizens themselves. In a word, public journalists want public life to work. The question remains whether public journalism represents a radical movement or a return to tradition.

7.2.1 Characteristics of Civic Journalism

The most prominent characteristic of the works on public journalism is its contentiousness. It deals with public journalism's goals, performance in implementing its goals, relation to democratic theory, the nature of practice, or the impact on communities. Today understanding the features of civic journalism or civic reporting has helped the people become aware of detailed news of serious and not so serious incidents.

“Citizen Journalism or Civic reporting” is one of those phrases that sound pretty straightforward. But, when a non-reporter gets to report an incident, most people aren’t exactly sure what it means. Basically, a citizen journalist is someone from outside the news business who engages in the kind of journalism that is traditionally the purview of the professional journalist.

Now the communication system has digitally advanced the media. In a digital world there is a complete host of different ways to communicate. Today, the value of amateur eyewitness film shot on a mobile phone and posted on the internet has added news value to the normal incidents. At times its popularity and usage has no less news value than a broadcast on a traditional television channel or published on a website.

Controlling how news is reported and disseminated is closely linked to power. That’s the reason why dictatorships have always iron handedly censored or removed the free press and run state TV stations. While much of the western world has moved ahead from that, media is often controlled by a certain group, making citizen journalism a vital part of opening up of reporting to everyone. But if it truly makes a lasting impact for good, citizen journalists need to understand their own responsibilities. Civic reporters should not to be biased, abide by the ethics and law and act accordingly.

Despite the potential drawbacks, there are plenty of reasons to welcome the rise of citizen journalism. The running term “Every Citizen is a Reporter,” has become an influential news resource in new media. Citizen journalism on the internet has also added blogs, chat rooms and message boards. All stripes provide a range of opinion and reporting far beyond what traditional

7.3 STRENGTHS AND LIMITATIONS

The spread of new technologies including blog sites, social networks, and the use of smart phones with cameras, allow members of the public without any journalistic training to participate and publish their own point of view about a range of subjects. Articles written by citizen journalists may contain anything within or even outside the news; however there have been debates as to whether this type of journalism is good or bad for mainstream media?

Strengths of citizen journalism:

- a) The common people are able to alert the media to news stories that they may not already know about, or that professional journalists have difficulty to cover.
- b) Citizen journalists can be a massive help by providing written reports in addition to photographs and videos in real time. For example many stories regarding the Arab Spring have been covered by citizen journalists when mainstream media were unable to reach areas of conflict or a media blackout was in place.
- c) Such kind of reporting produces evidence from the field.

Limitations of citizen journalism:

- a) Citizen journalists are not professionally trained, so subjectivity or bias may creep in their stories.
- b) Sometimes such stories may be of poor standard, and lack content.
- c) They may also not be aware of journalistic ethics which is a serious concern.
- d) The use of freedom of speech by a citizen journalist may result in libel. There were a number of cases in the past when people have been charged for statements they have published via social networks or online blogs as they were offensive or untrue.

Yet, citizen journalists complement mainstream media by providing speedier reports and information from a range of sources that allow mainstream media reports to be balanced cover more aspects and be more accurate.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the strengths and limitations of citizen journalism ?

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7.3.1 More About Civic Journalism

According to the now dormant Pew Center for Civic Journalism, the practice “is both a philosophy and a set of values supported by some evolving techniques to reflect both of these in journalism. At its heart is a belief that journalism has an obligation to public life – an obligation that goes beyond just telling the news or unloading lots of facts. The way we do our journalism affects the way public life goes.” Leading organisations in the field also include the Kettering Foundation, the Participatory Journalism Interest Group (formerly named the Civic and Citizen Journalism Interest Group) in the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) and the Public Journalism Network. Although they developed the concept of public journalism together, both Rosen and Merritt have differing viewpoints on what exactly public journalism is. Rosen explains five ways to understand public journalism:

- As an argument, a way of thinking about what journalist should be doing, given their own difficulty and general state of public life.
- As an experiment, a way of breaking out of established routines and making a different kind of contribution to public life.
- As a movement involving practicing journalists, former journalists who want to improve their craft, academics and researchers with ideas to lend and studies that might help, foundations and think tanks that gave

financial assistance and sanctuary to the movement, and other likeminded folk who wanted to contribute to the rising spirit of reform.

- As a debate with often heated conversation within the press and with others outside it about the proper role of the press.
- As an adventure, an open-ended and experimental quest for another kind of press.

Merritt, on the other hand, explains that it is the responsibility of the journalist to act as a fair-minded participant in the public arena. His famous analogy of the journalist having the same role as a sports referee best depicts this idea.

The function of a third party – a referee or umpire or judge – in sports competition is to facilitate the deciding of the outcome. Ideally, the official impinges on the game; if things go according to the rules is that the referee is neither seen nor heard. Yet the presence of a fair-minded participant is necessary for an equitable decision to be reached. What he or she brings to the arena is knowledge of the agreed-upon rules, the willingness to contribute that knowledge, and authority – that is, the right to be attended to. The referee’s role is to make sure that the process works as the contestants agreed it should. In order to maintain that authority, that right to be heard, the referee must exhibit no interest in the final score other than it is arrived at under the rules. But, both for referees and contestants, that is the ultimate interest. It is important to remember that the referee doesn’t make the rules. Those are agreed on by the contestants – in this case, the democratic public. The referee, rather, is the fair-minded caretaker. What the journalist should bring to the arena of public life is the knowledge of the rules – how the public has decided a democracy should work and the ability and the willingness to provide relevant information and a lace for that information to be discussed and turned into democratic consent. Like the referee, to maintain our authority – the right to be heard – we must exhibit no partisan interest in the specific outcome other than it is arrived at under the democratic process.

Merritt summed up civic journalism as “a set of values about the craft that recognizes and acts upon the interdependence between journalism and democracy. It values the concerns of citizens over the needs of the media and political actors, and conceives of citizens as stakeholders in the democratic process rather than as merely victims, spectators or inevitable adversaries. As inherent participants in the process, we should do our work in ways that aid in the resolution of public problems by fostering broad citizen engagement.”

7.4 ETHICS IN CIVIC REPORTING

Civic reporting on one hand is considered to be independent and detached, while on the other side it is also about participation, advocacy, and activism. A recent addition to the multi-sided pressures faced by the news industry (corporate media concentration and convergence, audience fragmentation, citizen journalism{bloggers}, fusing of news and entertainment, shifts in advertising revenue streams) is a growing international demand to restore an ethics of social responsibility for both the print and electronic press so that

the cultural diversity of the world may be fairly represented through stories, images and voices that are more inclusive.

Researches assumed that mainstream journalism constructs the poor, immigrants, refugees, indigenous peoples, or other excluded groups through third person sources, and, it is assumed that mainstream journalism rarely includes the voices of marginalized groups or addresses them directly. Civic journalism seeks to reduce the gap between groups being reported on and the journalist's implied audience by developing stories from where the subject (citizen or non-citizen) is situated. There is a need to develop a new set of ethics for civic journalism. The new ethics would hold journalism as a mediator of an ongoing public conversation among diverse groups rather than as a provider of neutral descriptions of agents, events, and issues.

This will be deepened through the first innovation in methodology which is the diagnosis and putting into question of genealogies of how subjects are conventionally framed. The second level of innovation contrasts genealogical critique of mainstream news framing with a blending of more inclusive storytelling techniques and pedagogical alternatives that will be tested through field experiments with practitioners, communities, and researchers.

7.4.1 Platform to Speak

The scope of citizen journalism is increased to manyfold with the creation of website by content creators. These websites, started by citizen journalists, focus on obtaining information important to their local area. Often these news stories are neglected by the mainstream media as they do not bring much viewership and thus profit to the organization. However, the creation of such sites enable the content producers to reach millions of people and also offers coverage of news that many news outlets are not able to cover.

According to American media critic Jay Rosen, writer of the blog pressthink.org, "Civic reporting is a power shift from professional journalism. People can talk back to the news system and make their own media. That's a power shift."

Talking in the Indian context, there was no sight of this 'power shift' in India. The mainstream press continued to outdo alternative forms of news expression like social media in popularity. Newspapers, news channels and news sites continued to relay the news; journalists continued to select and write it; and media owners may or may not tamper with it, while, the public was at the receptor end.

However, with time ordinary people have started reporting about the news they witness in their day-to-day life. Be it accidents, some activity of corruption or unethical happening, people constantly take over to their social media accounts to report such events. This may or may not be taken by news channels or newspapers. There is no doubt about the fact that citizen journalism has given a way to commoners to raise their voices against the issue of concern.

According to veteran journalist Shishir Joshi, "Citizen Journalism or civic reporting acquired the accoutrements of a movement in the early 2000s,

particularly in the US. But the origins of citizen journalism are as old as journalism, when pamphlets and reports were issued by citizens. Some of the most powerful pieces of journalistic writing can be traced back to the initiatives of citizens as reporters, not reporters as professionals.”

Some of the recent examples of citizen journalism include the Zomato controversy, where the delivery boy was photographed eating the order; Dominoes controversy, where pizza doughs were seen kept just below the moppers used for cleaning etc. Such incidents have been reported

Chances of censorship are fewer in citizen journalism. The mainstream media tend to privilege dominant voices that reproduce the status quo. Citizen journalism holds the promise of giving space to marginal voices and allowing for publication of alternate viewpoints.

7.4.2 Citizen Journalism Vs Professional Journalism: Responsibility, Adventure and Political Power

Some scholars believe that since citizen journalism is not a product of well-oiled mechanism, hence it might not be as efficient as the professional journalism.

Civic reporting is a kind of collaborative relationship in which the information goes from the bottom; citizen journalist, up to professional ones. A civic reporter plays an important part in making the news whether it is breaking news or a featured item. But it is also true that it takes years of training and practice to become a journalist and the discipline is subject to code of practice, ethics and is governed by law. A good journalist is expected to go through proper training, however, there is not such expectation from the civic reporters.

- A civic reporter is merely an eye witness. Taking a picture, a video and giving an account of an event no matter how good the quality, does not make one a journalist.
- Journalists are trained persons. They follow the rules of the profession even in photography. They are cautious enough to maintain the anonymity of the subject, which might not be the case with the citizen journalist.
- Challenges such as one-sided views in politics and current affairs, publications of defamatory material frequent in citizen journalism practices tarnish journalism and portray professional journalist in bad light.
- New media technology such as social networking e.g.: Twitter, Facebook etc., have given every citizens the ability to transmit information globally; a power which was once only reserved for large media corporations.
- In addition, the increasing presence, speed and accessibility of advanced smartphones and other media sharing devices have allowed citizen journalists to report on breaking news not only to a larger, global

audience, but also more quickly than traditional news reporters. Many believe this form of news coverage is fundamental to Journalism today; citizens' being relatable, unrestricted and available to capture images and footage of worldwide news as it breaks.

- Some researchers argue that since citizen journalists have lack of training, ethics and accountability they might give air to rumors, factual news, spreading of incorrect or misleading information and opinion rather than truth.
- Traditional journalism is the outside looking in and citizen journalism is the inside looking out. In order to get the complete story, it helps to have both points of view.

Activity

Search and write five memorable Indian examples of citizen journalism that played a vital role in getting the truth out.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Compare between citizen journalists and professional journalists.

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7.5 LET US SUM UP

Citizen Journalism plays a crucial role in democracy, politics, government and civic life. Civic reporting involves active participation of citizens in newsgathering and reporting. At times play a multiple role of exposing corruption, encouraging accountability, documenting abuses of power, and giving alternative views on local and international current affairs.

Citizen journalism is known to inform and educate and report from within a crisis so as to enrich traditional journalism for the general public to better understand the story. Civic reporting is also a reflection of personal emotion, opinion and or belief. This can be dangerous for objective news. So, collaborating with mainstream journalism will add value to it.

Though the primary aim of journalism is to be objective and unbiased, citizen journalism can sometimes compromise news values on factual account. While, professional journalism follows strict codes of ethics, it is not mandatory for citizen journalism. The basic aim of citizen journalism is provide common people a platform where they can satisfy their journalistic desires. Also, another very important goal of civic journalism is that provides support to the mainstream media for the coverage of even the tiniest news happening around the globe.

7.6 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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7.7 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Strengths and limitations of citizen journalism are as follows:

Strengths of citizen journalism :

- a) The common people are able to alert the media to news stories that they may not already know about, or that professional journalists have difficulty to cover.
- b) Citizen journalists can be a massive help by providing written reports in addition to photographs and videos in real time. For example many stories regarding the Arab Spring have been covered by citizen journalists when mainstream media were unable to reach areas of conflict or a media blackout was in place.
- c) Such kind of reporting produces evidence from the field.

Limitations of citizen journalism :

- a) Citizen journalists are not professionally trained, so subjectivity or bias may creep in their stories.
- b) Sometimes such stories may be of poor standard, and lack content.
- c) They may also not be aware of journalistic ethics which is a serious concern.
- d) The use of freedom of speech by a citizen journalist may result in libel. There were a member of cases in the past when people have been charged for statements they have published via social networks or online blogs as they were offensive or untrue.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Comparison between citizen and professional journalists.

- A citizen journalist is merely an eye witness. Taking a picture, a video and giving an account of an event no matter how good the quality. But, professional journalists are trained persons. They follow the rules of the profession even in photography. They are cautious enough to maintain the anonymity of the subject, which might not be the case with the citizen journalist.
- Traditional journalism is the outside looking in and citizen journalism is the inside looking out. In order to get the complete story, it helps to have both points of view.



UNIT 8 REPORTING SOCIAL ISSUES

Structure

- 8.0 Introduction
- 8.1 Learning Outcomes
- 8.2 Media and Social Problems
- 8.3 Social Media and Social Issues
- 8.4 Media's Role in Spreading Awareness
- 8.5 Social Issues in Media
 - 8.5.1 Health and Hygiene
 - 8.5.2 Media and Education
 - 8.5.3 Media and Environment
 - 8.5.4 Media and Children/Women
 - 8.5.5 Media and Senior Citizens
- 8.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 8.7 References and Further Reading
- 8.8 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

8.0 INTRODUCTION

In a developing country like India, reporting issues having social relevance is very important. Issues like health, poverty, education, disability etc. are critical topics which require the attention of government and common public through media. This unit will help the learner to understand several dimensions of social issue reporting. The unit is designed keeping in mind a logistic view of social problems. In the Indian context, such issues are multi facet and interlinked. This unit will focus more on the issues of the larger population which has a common thread across all socio-economic classes like old age and disability.

Recent years have seen rise in the understanding of the significance and centrality of social issues among the public. The increase in number of requirements around the world seeking the disclosure of social metrics and information has given way to more serious reporting on these issues. The understanding of common public about the social issues is also evolving with time.

8.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you will be able to:

- understand broadly the social issues of Indian society;
- describe the role of media as an element of social change; and
- analyze the need and kind of media coverage required for social issues.

8.2 MEDIA AND SOCIAL PROBLEMS

India is a country with diverse background. People here belong to different color, cast, creed and culture. With diversity, comes lot of challenges that the country has to face. Be it over population, poverty, education and health & hygiene etc, social issues have always been a matter of concern for our country. Media plays an important role in bridging the gap between common people and the policy makers. In a democracy, media have the power and responsibility to inform and inspire people to political action. However, to achieve this one requires a deep understanding of current social problems and how the policy is formulated. Also, a journalist reporting on social issues needs to have the ability to raise the issue in a storytelling manner, that drives public into action.

According to a recent UN report on “Population”, India remains the second most populous country of the world after China. However, the report suggests that around 2023, India is projected to overtake China as the world’s most populous country. Some of the reasons for increase in population quoted by UN are fertility rates, increasing longevity and international migration.

With increased population come various other issues like poverty, health and education. A journalist reporting on such issues need to be sensitive towards the problems he/she is highlighting in his/her report. To bring out empathy among the readers and policy makers, it is important that the journalist himself/herself is sensitive enough. Among the several problems our society is facing, economic problems occupy an important position. Poverty is the reality of our society and a big number of families have income far below the level, which would ensure a reasonable standard of living. As people live longer and into much advanced age (75 years and over), they need more intensive and long-term care, which in turn may increase financial needs. Inadequate income is a major problem of elderly in India. The most vulnerable are those who do not own productive assets, have little or no savings or income from investments made earlier, have no pension or retirement benefits, and are not taken care of by their children or live in families that have uncertain low incomes and many mouths to feed.

8.3 SOCIAL MEDIA AND SOCIAL ISSUES

The penetration of online media has increased to manyfold after the outbreak of COVID 19 and things going online in India. Many people, including those who aren’t very tech-savvy, have started using social media aggressively, be it social networking platforms like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram or messaging app WhatsApp. These sites allow users to share pictures and other information with more people conveniently. A large population is connected through social networking. For many, social networking is a way to connect with people, however, not just building relationships, but also social media help to bring all the current topics to our knowledge and discussions. Several online platforms like Facebook, Twitter and Instagram, provide us with overall awareness about our current societal issues. A socially relevant picture or a message from any of the user can circulate to mass population in just fraction of seconds. Even though social media is majorly used as a tool of

citizen journalism, its potential towards main stream journalism cannot be ignored.

8.4 MEDIA'S ROLE IN SPREADING AWARENESS

Based on the existing diversities in the social issues, media needs to pay greater attention to the increasing awareness on these issues and its socio-economic effects in order to promote the development of policies for dealing with them.

The unbiased reporting of social issues like old age will call for the concerted efforts of the Government, Non-Government organizations, religious institutions and individuals not only to understand, but also to solve or at least mitigate the whole gamut of problems resulting from a greying society so that the aged people can lead dignified and meaningful life.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. How do you think social media can help in tackling social issues in a developing country like India?

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8.5 SOCIAL ISSUES AND MEDIA COVERAGE

Media coverage is invaluable for publicizing the issues and difficulties faced by people such as- health and hygiene, poverty, education etc.

8.5.1 Health and Hygiene

In India majority of the population has to spend from their pockets for an illness. One major health stroke in a family may wipe out the entire family's savings of a life time. It is the time media through awareness campaigns wakes up the government to completely revamp the health care in India for the elderly. Improved health care facilities, advanced equipments, geriatric wards in hospitals must be made easily accessible to the poor in rural areas with the yearly allocation of state funds. Government needs to make detailed and tangible action plan for the various schemes launched and a definite time-line for their implementation. The challenge for India, as for all countries over the world, is not only to add further years to life, but more importantly to add life to years and to ensure that the elderly are able to live full, enriching and productive lives and for this to be possible, good health is the key. It is the prime responsibility of the journalists reporting social issues to highlight such problems being faced by the public. Bridging the gap between the common people and the government is the role of news media.

In order to provide better sanitation and hygiene facilities to the public, the government takes various measures at the national and international level.

International organizations like The World Bank, United Nations, etc. play significant role in highlighting the significance of basic amenities and social infrastructure to address right to health and other human rights. 73rd Amendment to the Constitution (243G of Eleventh Schedule) assigns rural housing, sanitation and drinking water inclusive of 29 duties to Panchayats. Issue like open defecation is a matter of concern for almost all organizations in India. The international organizations UNICEF and World Health Organization (WHO) regularly collect data on open defecation and publish. The term 'Open Defecation' is used throughout the world for throwing faeces in the open field, roadside, agriculture field, forest or any available space. Government of India formulates plans and policies related to sanitation and implemented through State governments and Local body institutions.

The outbreak of corona virus in 2020 brought challenges to not just the survival of human beings but also to media covering every bit of it. A need or more credible and authentic news stories were felt. It was felt that media doesn't need to scare people of the mishappenings taking place around the globe because of COVID-19. Here, the reporter was supposed to be sensible enough to differentiate between what is right and what is wrong. It was seen that lot of fake news and rumors circulated through social media and we know that social media do not have any gatekeeping process. Journalists need to understand their responsibility of providing credible, useful and authentic information in such types of adverse situations.

8.5.2 Media and Education

The importance of education has been discussed about since ages. According to the great philosopher Swami Vivekananda, "education as the manifestation of perfection already in man. Like fire in a piece of flint, knowledge exists in mind. The suggestion is the friction, which brings it out." Mahatma Gandhi suggested that "By education, I mean an all-around drawing out of the best in the child and man's body, mind and spirit." According to Greek philosopher Plato "education develops in the body and the soul of the pupil all the beauty and all the perfection he is capable of. Education is the creation of sound mind in a sound body." Education is a broad concept and has played a crucial role in the development of the society from the ancient times till today.

The social issues a country is going through are all interconnected. Education is considered as an essential component/factor from eradicating poverty and sustenance of fair democratic processes in today's societies. Literacy is the vital for the overall development of individuals and for the social and economic development of a country. Education is one of the three dimensions of the Human Development Index (HDI). Considering the importance of education in a developing economy, media has the responsibility to act as a bridge between government's education policies and people. Media has role to play in letting the people know about the advantages of being educated, and also about the problems they may face by being uneducated. A number of experiments are taking place now a days in the era of online education. A number of open learning platforms like ePathshala, SWAYAM, etc. have been launched to promote education in the semi-urban and rural areas. A number of initiatives in higher education have been launched by the

government with the help of ICT.

8.5.3 Media and Environment

Environment is an important social issue that needs to be addressed by the media. In a progressive society, it is inevitable that environment and development go hand in hand. Humans are part of nature and environment is an inseparable part of life support systems. Climate change is one of the major issues of our time. Many UNESCO programmes in the science, education, culture and communication contribute to creating knowledge, educating and communicating about climate change, and to understand the ethical implications for present and future generations. With a drastic climate change observed from past several years, it becomes a matter of concern. To understand the co-existence of humanity and environment, and to deal with the climate change, several organizations are working including United Nations, International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) etc.

The rapid expansion and breakthroughs in the arena of science and technology have ushered human race into a new age. Media plays a crucial role in forming public opinion and influencing policy decisions. An ordinary citizen gains confidence and capacity to become effective agents of change when aware of environment and development related issues. Media works as the information disseminator among the people. It also works as an agent of change. Brings about change in the society by altering the mindset of people. Also, mass media activates latent attitudes, promoting people to take action. It helps in mobilizing the masses for collective action by appealing to people's conscience to participate in various environmental conservation and support activities like promoting use of cloth bags instead of poly bags, throwing the garbage in dustbin and not littering it on road etc.

8.5.4 Media and Children/Women

Reporting stories on children and women needs to be carefully tackled. Several social issues such as child labour, female feticide, dowry, early marriage etc. revolves around the broad spectrum of women and children.

UNICEF has worked a lot to develop proper guidelines for journalists to cover children's issues. They are also working to create awareness among the media professionals about responsible way to cover children related issues in news media. They developed six overarching principles, six guidelines for interviewing children, and seven principles for reporting children related issues in media. You can see these principles and guidelines on website of UNICEF by clicking this link : <https://www.unicef.org/eca/media/ethical-guidelines#:~:text=Six%20guidelines%20for%20interviewing%20children,-Do%20no%20harm&text=Ensure%20that%20the%20child%20or,when%20possible%2C%20for%20documentary%20photographs>.

One more guideline has been developed for responsible representation and reporting of violence against children and women. It was developed by UNFPA, UNICEF and UN Women in the Asia-Pacific and South Asia region. It was an output of a joint working group to enhance and prioritise messaging and communications on violence against women and children

amid and in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic. According to UNICEF's official website, *"These guidelines promote responsible and effective representation and reporting of violence against women and violence against children for public advocacy purposes, such as media coverage and awareness raising campaigns. While the causes, risk factors, prevalence, patterns and consequences of violence against women and violence against children may differ, many of the considerations for ethically, safely and effectively communicating these issues are crosscutting."*

These guidelines are intended for media practitioners, United Nations country offices and other development and civil society organisations communicating about violence against women and violence against children."

The guidelines suggest that while reporting violence stories against women or children, a reporter must keep a survivor-centred approach. Content should ideally provide calls-to-action, including information about locally available support services. The content should be produced in the languages of the target populations and sensationalising violence by depicting violent acts in detail should be avoided in all types of content, whether visual, audio and written. Also, a journalist should avoid 'victim-blaming' or suggesting that survivors are responsible for causing or provoking violence. In a developing country like India, violence against women and children is common. However, that doesn't make it an easy to go story. A journalist should always be mindful of these guidelines issued by UNICEF in the public interest.

8.5.5 Media and Senior Citizens

Media has an important role to play in highlighting different social issues. Journalists should identify the emerging social issues and by giving adequate coverage to them, they can finally help in finding out solutions too. Issues faced by elderly people in the present society also require media attention. It should restrain from creating fear psychosis by responsible reporting, promoting intergenerational bonds and informing individuals, families, groups with appropriate information on ageing process. Resident Welfare Associations should encourage people to speak about such issues at special events organized by local government, which the media can attend. RWA's can run media awards for the best coverage of these issues. RWA's should organize an eye-catching event with older people, such as dramas or demonstrations.

Journalists can work on new angles for everyday stories such as a child being looked after by his grandparents who has excelled in his school exams. Plans, policies and accomplishments for the elderly by the government may be highlighted on earmarked days and anniversaries. Journalists may also highlight unusual or touching stories about amazing individuals such as an older man caring for his sick son/daughter or an older woman who has set up an older people's club where they can all meet to pursue their hobbies like reading, playing cards, watching movies and so on. Young people often think old age is something they do not need to think about for a very long time, but actually everyone needs to consider it as we all have a part to play in the way in which age and being old is treated in society.

Based on the existing diversities in the ageing process, media needs to pay greater attention to the increasing awareness on the ageing issues and its socio-economic effects in order to promote the development of policies for dealing with an ageing society. The unbiased reporting of social issues like old age will call for the concerted efforts of the Government, Non-Government organizations, religious institutions and individuals not only to understand, but also to solve or at least mitigate the whole gamut of problems resulting from a greying society so that the aged people can lead dignified and meaningful life.

The media should continue to spread awareness amongst people regarding the legal rights they have in hand for fighting against the atrocities they are subjected to. Under these rights parents cannot be evicted from a house without due process of law if they have been staying there from before. They can also demand maintenance from children in the same way that a wife can demand it from her husband. The domestic violence act too provides parents with the right to seek relief from any kind of abuse. Nationwide programmes in schools and colleges through media should sensitize children and young adults towards ageing and the needs of elderly people. In the present scenario of nuclear families, awareness about social value of senior citizen needs to be created. These days a large section of the senior citizens is living alone as either the younger generation does not have the time to take care or consider it a burden. Many of them now prefer to be independent in their own homes or want to lead a hassle-free life in senior citizens homes. The trend of appointing care takers to give company to elderly is fast catching up. People should be given training to become professional care takers of elderly.

Now old people are mustering courage to speak up and report about painful legal battles over property and other crime and abuse against them by their own children and families. Innovative campaigns along with media coverage can help them regain their lost esteem and assets. Road traffic accidents have been a cause of death for those aged above 60 years partly by fast moving vehicles and partly on account of badly designed roads. The disabled or aged persons are not in the thought process of people in-charge of redesigning urban infrastructure to make it elderly friendly. Footpaths should be statutorily arranged and adequate speed breakers should be provided to protect pedestrians from road accidents.

With increasing options and services available for post-retirement life, one should plan old age with excitement so that it is hassle free and secure. The elderly should try not to depend on children or have any expectation from them as non-fulfillment of these expectations will only lead to misery. The elderly at one time used to be the most respected members of the family and taking care of them was the responsibility of their children. However, the growth of individualism, materialism among the youth in today's modern and fast paced life coupled by western influence has led to their alienation and isolation from the families. Migration from rural areas also resulted in the growth of nuclear families in the towns and cities.

Media can definitely help in bring about a change in society's attitude by continuously highlighting the emerging issues and areas of action for elders.

The correct and right portrayal of elderly people in the mass media influences the viewer's explicit and implicit attitudes and beliefs towards them and old age. The most important deterrent in senior citizen's mobility is the lack of safe and convenient public transport. For those who would like self-driving, the chaotic dangerous traffic conditions frighten them. Journalists should not shy away from covering and highlighting the non-availability of age friendly, barrier free access in buses, bus stops, railway stations, airports and transportation within the airports, banks and hospitals where they have to stand in the common queue and do not have a separate seating area in parks, places of worship, cinema halls, shopping malls and other places that senior citizens and the disabled frequent.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is the importance of media coverage of social issues like healthcare, education and environment?

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8.6 LET US SUM UP

Media is considered the fourth pillar of democracy in India after the judiciary, legislature and executive. There are many responsibilities on its shoulders. Media is influential and has the ability to shape opinion of its audience on any issue. Due to its such characteristics, the media remains powerful in a developing country like India, which is grappling with many social issues. The media has capabilities to make the public aware about illiteracy, over population, poverty, old age, pollution and various ill effects of social evils like child labour, dowry etc. A reporter's job is to fearlessly report the truth. Every day the Central Government, Governments of various states, various government departments and ministers inform the public about the various development works going on in the country. This is done through press releases, handbooks, newspapers, yearbooks, reports or press conferences etc. Journalists reporting on social issues should always disseminate this information to the public so that they can be made aware of it. However, the duty of journalists reporting on social issues is not only to provide information about various development policies and programs to the public, but also to describe the impact on the lives of the people related to the proposed development.

Senior citizens need immediate attention. What they need is understanding, love and care, not our pity. Media and educational institutions have a huge responsibility on their shoulders to make youth aware about the rights and privileges of senior citizens. It is our responsibility, both individually and collectively, to ensure that these rights are fulfilled. Don't make them feel irrelevant, rather make them feel an integral part of our lives.

In India, unlike many western countries, parents live with their children even after the age of 18 (of course there are exceptions). They are ready to bear the responsibility of their children for a long time. But after a long time, many times parents just want to relax and want their kids to take care of them too. Every parent wants to see their child grow and succeed but no parent wants their child to consider their responsibilities towards them as an unnecessary burden. It is our duty to see that they do not spend the last years of their lives in isolation, pain and suffering. Therefore, elderly persons require critical support that will maintain important aspects of their lifestyle while improving their overall quality of life.

Therefore, it is necessary for the media to not only examine the policies and programs launched by the government, but also see that their implementation is within the time limit. Apart from this, it should be ensured that there is no unnecessary economic burden of taxes and medical treatment on the elderly. And most importantly, the media has to do its best to sensitize today's youth to accept their responsibility towards their elders so that old age is a boon and a blessing to be enjoyed and lived to the fullest. It should be clear to all of us that we all have to face this stage.

8.7 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READING

Responsible representation and reporting of violence against women and violence against children, <https://www.unicef.org/rosa/documents/responsible-representation-and-reporting-violence-against-women-and-violence-against-0>

Dhandekar. K.-The Elderly in India New Delhi. Sage publications.

Gurmurthy K.G. – The Aged in India New Delhi Reliance Publishing House.

United Nations report on Ageing.

Ageing in Rural India perspectives & prospects. Delhi. Indian Publishers Distributors,

Various other articles from newspapers like Hindu, The Times of India, Hindustan Times.

8.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

Refer to 8.3

Check Your Progress 2

Refer to 8.4.1, 8.4.2, 8.4.3

UNIT 9 REPORTING LIFESTYLE, FASHION AND FILMS

Structure

- 9.0 Introduction
- 9.1 Learning Outcomes
- 9.2 Lifestyle Reporting
- 9.3 Evolution of Fashion in India
 - 9.3.1 Has Indian Fashion Come of Age?
 - 9.3.2 Strengths
- 9.4 Fashion Journalism
 - 9.4.1 Steps to Begin Fashion Reporting
- 9.5 Scouting for Ideas
 - 9.5.1 Fashion and Lifestyle Products
 - 9.5.2 Role of Fashion Designers
 - 9.5.3 Fashion Photography
 - 9.5.4 Fashion Show Choreography
 - 9.5.5 Modeling for Print and Television
- 9.6 Reporting a Fashion Show
- 9.7 Writing on Fashion Trends
- 9.8 Basic Terminologies
- 9.9 Other Lifestyle Prospects
 - 9.9.1 Yoga and Fitness
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 - 9.9.3 Book
- 9.10 Let Us Sum Up
- 9.11 Further Readings
- 9.12 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

9.0 INTRODUCTION

Fashion is a term none of us are unaware about. Everyday we tend to consume fashion in some or the other way. Media plays an important role in penetrating fashion sense into the society as everyone looks upon the media to know more about it. Fashion in general is considered as a guide to lead a better life. The dresses and accessories worn by the elites and celebrities set a benchmark for people belonging to middle class. Bollywood, one of the largest producers of films in the world, has a greater impact on people. In general sense people consider film actors as their role models. Country has huge number of viewers, actors and actresses and their die-hard fans. People are curious to know about the latest movies, storylines, dialogues and personal and professional lives of their favourite actors. This has led to the creation of a number of big media houses publishing innumerable

newspapers, magazines and producing audio-visual programs focusing on fashion related contents. Mainstream news bulletins and newspapers too keep searching for latest updates in the fields of fashion, lifestyle and films.

9.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, the learner will be able to:

- gain insight into the current scenario of fashion in India;
- understand the scope and importance of lifestyle reporting in the country;
- discuss how to promote these products through advertising, press conferences, fashion shows, press releases and interviews of film actors and celebrities; and
- report and produce content for specialised publications and programmes on fashion.

9.2 LIFESTYLE REPORTING

Oxford Research Encyclopedias define Lifestyle Journalism as “a distinct journalistic field that primarily addresses its audiences as consumers, providing them with news they can use”. Even though lifestyle reporting goes hand in hand with other genres of journalism, it has not been the focus of much scholarly debate. Lifestyle journalism has frequently been defined in opposition to the normative ideal of journalism. It can be considered as the fusion of journalistic elements such as soft news, service journalism, consumer journalism, popular journalism or even cultural journalism. Lifestyle journalism imbibes in itself more specialized beats of journalism like travel journalism, fashion journalism or food journalism. However, several experts believe that the field of lifestyle journalism is characterized by blurred boundaries, both between the various subfields and between soft and hard news. For example: Lifestyle story with soft news angle can be - How to improve your heart health, and lifestyle story with hard news angle can be: smoking causes economic expenses.

In general terms, lifestyle covers luxurious way of living. Lifestyle reporting is a moderate form of journalism wherein writers can take time to scout for ideas, work on them and present it before the readers in an entertaining way. Relevant pictures can also accompany such pieces accentuating the theme of the story.

With increase in internet penetration in the country, more and more people can access fashion icons globally. Also, with time people have become more health conscious, specially after the outbreak of COVID-19. This has resulted in the increase in the number of write ups on fashion and lifestyle issues appearing in newspapers and magazines catering to general readers. These reports are mainly about various events taking place in these fields such as fashion shows, exhibitions, press conferences and interviews with fashion designers, models, fashion photographers, choreographers, stylists, dieticians, yoga experts, authors, travel experts etc. The trade magazines covering business of lifestyle products too have donned a new contemporary look with

increase in readership. All these developments have created ample opportunities for journalists having flair for fashion to make a mark in their career.

Lifestyle Journalism is a specialised area of writing. Reporting of lifestyle news is done in feature style, wherein contents are presented in the style of a news feature, ignoring the basics of journalistic writings comprising answers to 5 Ws and 1H. News reports on fashion and lifestyle should be such that they interest readers.

9.3 EVOLUTION OF FASHION IN INDIA

Fashion is an integral part of any society. Every society has got its individual characteristic style of clothing and lifestyle, which is defined as fashion of that particular society. India with its rich cultural heritage has got an important place in the world of fashion. Literature on the age old Indus Valley Civilization suggests that men clothing was restricted to a lion cloth, while women used to cover their upper body with jewels and the metal of the jewellery used to determine the status of a women at that time.

Fashion in India has evolved to a great extent since then. History suggests that Aryans introduced two distinct clothes for upper and lower parts of the body for women and the trend continues till today. References abound in Indian literature about weaving and designing of various types of textiles which speak volumes of a vibrant tradition in the field. Rigveda is supposed to contain the first literary information about textiles in India. The traditional age-old textiles, crafts such as embroidery, beading, aari, thread embroidery, zardozi and jewellery have not only enticed elite class in other countries but have also been source of inspiration for several reputed European fashion designers. Still today, the charm of India's traditional clothing and jewellery items holds true to them

The influence of fashion from one community to another has travelled through media. It is believed that the advent of the specialist fashion media in West Europe is responsible for the development of the modern fashion industry. The epicenter of modern women's fashion is considered to be Paris. The concept of fashion journalism was developed to disseminate and promote what was fashionable in the French capital. The dominance of the French media continued until the early twentieth century, when U.S. publishers started to make inroads into Europe.

The major boost to the fashion and lifestyle products industry which broadly covers the business activities in the field of apparels, textiles, jewellery, lifestyle items and related accessories came in 1970s when the country took up the export of fashion items seriously.

To promote all these fashion items, manufacturers and designers organise a variety of promotional activities in the country. Products displayed through live models i.e. fashion shows, however, remain the most popular of all promotional activities. These activities are covered extensively by print media, electronic media and online media. Dedicated pages in newspapers and shows on television channels, cater to audience who have keen interest in

fashion and lifestyle. As print advertisements and fashion shows have become part and parcel of the industry, models and fashion photographers are much sought after people. To tap the potential of fashion and lifestyle industry, the government take steps to promote export of textiles, jewellery, leather and other life-style items time and again. Training institutes such as National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT), National Institute of Design (NID), Fashion Design Development Institute (FDDI) etc work together to create a positive image of Indian products and setup worldwide.

9.3.1 Has Indian Fashion Come of Age?

In India, fashion design council has been formed which is organising Fashion Weeks wherein leading designers showcase their creations attracting buyers from foreign countries. Even the standard of fashion shows has improved to match the international standards. Fashion events are serious events aimed at attracting attention of foreign and local buyers. People now a days have become brand conscious. They look for ready-made designer cloths and apparel and prefer not to go to local tailoring shops. Therefore, it won't be wrong to say that fashion trends in India have evolved and have got changed with time. People have become more trendy who like to move ahead with fashion.

9.3.2 Strength

Rich cultural heritage, skilled manpower and abundance of raw materials are the strengths of India in terms of fashion and its products. India is a country with rich and diverse culture. Each state of the country comes with its own uniqueness. For example Benarasi saris, kanjeevaram saris, Gujarati and Rajasthani dresses and Kutch mirror work are famous throughout the world. People from all across the globe visit the country to buy different kinds of fabric. You name a state and it will have its own unique fabric and design style. As far as raw material is concerned, India is the largest producer of cotton and jute and second biggest producer of silk after China. Indian fashion is not new, it has come of age, flowing through the rich cultural heritage.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Discuss the strengths of India in the fashion sector.

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9.4 FASHION JOURNALISM

Caryn Franklin, a journalist, once said in 2013 that, “fashion is an industry that has very cleverly created its own media to support it.” Which means that fashion industry comes with its own set of journalists and fashion enthusiastic

who passionately like to follow the changing trends of fashion and report it for other people. Some experts firmly believe that journalists are a crucial cog in the fashion wheel, acting as gatekeepers declaring what is in and what is out. Fashion journalists play a crucial role in making new trends sound desirable and explaining a designer's ideas to the public. Just like always, media acts as a bridge between the fashion industry and the public. Also, media is considered to be largely responsible for setting a trend among people in a particular society/community.

In the nineteenth century, fashion journalism was one of the few career options open to women, particularly in France. Although they had no formal fashion training, many of the innovative editors of the fashion press were women, including Emmeline Raymond of *La Mode Illustrée*, for example. These women were primarily fashion writers who informed readers on current fashions as well as on matters of social etiquette and good taste, although they also took charge of the overall look and content of the magazines. Raymond used her renown as a fashion editor to write books on embroidery and etiquette that were translated and sold in Britain and Germany. It was not until after World War II that fashion journalism became an internationally recognized profession and that newspapers as well as magazines employed staff journalists to cover fashion.

Some critics argue that fashion journalism is part of a broader cultural discourse. Even though it is perceived as feminine and trivial and therefore provides an easy target for negative commentary, it is at the forefront of cultural change. The growth of international style networks and blogs has democratized and demystified the discourse of fashion. Also, the system of media changed as the system of fashion changed. Fast fashion introduced new types of magazines or change in the frequency of the old magazines. Fashion was earlier considered to be a preoccupation of social elites. However, the fashion system grew with the development of mass media. We now have hardcore fashion magazine and tv channels which illustrates the latest dress styles that can be donned by even the common man.

Even though a fashion journalist's job responsibility varies as per the demands of the organization one is working for, the basic premise on which he/she is employed is to keep the readers up to date on style trends. Almost every newspaper today carries a fashion related content. If a reporter works for a newspaper or news magazine, he/she has to look after the pages/sections dedicated to fashion and lifestyle stories. On these pages, the fashion journalist reports about only those issues which are of interest to general readers like the latest trends in fashion and interviews with leading professionals in the field. The approach to the write-ups is simple and informative.

However, journalists working in a magazine or TV channel or online portal dedicated to fashion and lifestyle are not limited to just reporting on an event, fashion show etc. They ought to critically analyse the whole scenario keeping in mind the trends in vogue in other parts of the world as well like runways in fashion capitals of Paris, Milan, London, New York etc. A reporter must keep in mind that the subscribers of such magazines are mainly those who are

professionally associated with the field or have keen interest in fashion industry. Therefore, it is a must that the reporter work on well researched articles.

9.4.1 Steps to Begin Fashion Reporting

Fashion is something which is read and followed throughout the globe. It is not concerned with a particular community. Therefore, there are certain prerequisites that should be followed for someone who wants to start a career as fashion journalist.

1. Good command over language particularly English: As most of the magazines are published in English, it is important that the reporter must have good command over the language.
2. Flair for fashion: Having news sense and passion for fashion are other pre-requisites. One needs to be thorough with the information on fashion industry in the country. He/she should be aware about the trends in vogue across the globe and also about the historical trends.
3. To know basic terminologies used in the industry: To be a good fashion journalist it is important that the reporter is well versed with the terms used to the fashion industry.
4. Maintaining good public relations: Since a journalist has to base his/her writing on the quotes of professionals and facts and figures provided by various sources, s/he should be good at public relations. In fact, good public relations with designers, fashion photographers, models, fashion show choreographers etc. is very important in fashion journalism. People associated with this business do not easily share their trade secrets.

9.5 SCOUTING FOR IDEAS

Fashion and lifestyle is comparatively a new subject for writers and journalists to work on. They need to know various components of fashion and lifestyle before writing on the same. When we say fashion, there are various attributes to it. Some of which are briefly discussed below.

9.5.1 Fashion and Lifestyle Products

Today India occupies a prominent place as a manufacturer of fashion and lifestyle products, which includes textile, jewellery, garments, leather products, gems and stones, fashion accessories including bags, footwear, eyewear, belts, watches, stoles and scarves etc. These items are also exported to other countries. The growth in Institutes imparting training in design elements and technological innovation have helped promote these products which come into the market in an array of colours and designs. Further, these materials are being properly displayed by shop owners through windows to attract attention of the visitors. Called Visual merchandisers, these window shop designers work on two counts, exterior and interior, of the shop. They display products to casual visitors in such an enticing manner that they are inclined to visit the shop. Several brands organize Fashion Shows and Press Conferences and release press statements on the launch of new products. For

sales and after sales services, the lifestyle industry deploys trained merchandisers. They are mainly responsible for sourcing quality finished and unfinished items and making the final products available to customers as per the latest trends. This section would help you to figure out products and careers/professionals involved from manufacture to the business of fashion and lifestyle items. You can prepare your write-ups on these matters.

Activity - 1

Visit a local exhibition of garments and other lifestyle items, displaying products from different states. Write about it.

9.5.2 Role of Fashion Designers

Like never before people today have become conscious of their appearance and well-being. Flaunting dresses that are chic and trendy and look fabulous have become a common feature; particularly among the youngsters. Among the heterogeneous group of people, some are conscious about the trendy looking dress while others are conscious about the brand which they are wearing. Therefore, the manufacturer of the dress and the fashion designer plays an important role in the success of the product. A reputed designer has got better potential in the market than one from a lesser-known garment house. As a result, there is cut throat competition among various garment manufacturing units to take a lead by coming out with trendy garments.

Though a fashion designer's primary responsibility relates to innovative development of the garments through their technical expertise in cutting, draping and styling, their job profile varies based on the organization they are working in. The fashion designers today are no less than a celebrity. They are seen to be in close connection with the media persons covering the fashion and lifestyle beat. The popular designers are very often seen to be part of the news media and also of fashion magazines. So, fashion designers are also the important source of fashion related content in media.

9.5.3 Fashion Photography

Fashion photography is a specialized genre of photography. Fashion photography involves creating a total ambience for the garment while highlighting its focal points. In fact, fashion photography is the only media to communicate a designer's creations to a wider audience and it is through this special work of art that the ambience can be created, and the mood reflected. So, no more two-dimensional sketches of the garments and stereo-typed photographs of the model that focused on face. The fashion photographers using their specific skills enhance the actual value of the photographs of models.

9.5.4 Fashion Show Choreography

Fashion shows are being organized from past several years. They are a way to showcase the changing trends in the fashion industry. However, they are being programmed in a more streamlined manner now with a proper choreography. The focus of choreographers these days being on attracting

buyer's attention on the minutest details of the latest collections. And so, the choreography has now improved to become a specialized medium of enhancing focal points of the dresses. Fashion show choreographers work closely with fashion designers to help create a fashion show that reflects the mood and feel of the collection. They also coach the models on how to walk for a particular collection.

Modeling: In general terms, a fashion model is someone who wears the garments and try to persuade common people with his/her presentable and glamorous appeal. A model is someone who is admired by others and people aspire to be like him/her. The fashion models create a strong impact on the people irrespective of their age group. It is because they always make public appearances dressed in best of attires with their hair and face neatly done. In the olden times, modeling was considered to be an out and out female profession, but with time the scene has changed. There has been a drastic change in the last two decades with male models making their presence felt in all types of modeling- be it print/ commercial or ramp modelling.

Be it the launch of drinks or that of cars and computers, fashion shows have become part and parcel of the celebrations associated with such events. The recent positive development in the field is that fashion shows in India are following the trends of those in European countries. Indian designers are holding shows abroad to prove their worth, providing Indian models exposure to international ramps. A ramp model, thus, has the opportunity to acquire worldwide recognition as such fashion shows are recorded and repeatedly telecast on fashion channels. Performing live makes it a challenging and glamorous career and proper choreography gives an edge to this profession.

9.5.5 Modelling for Print and Television

Models who are hired for modeling in print ads, brouchers, catalogues, calendars and other printed items are considered to be models for print. There are plenty of opportunities for freshers in this form of modeling because of the volume of players in it. Thousands of newspapers and magazines are being published in the country; all big manufacturing companies print calendars and brochures, besides press advertisements released regularly by companies – from small to giant ones. The importance of print media cannot be ignored. It is one of the oldest form of communication.

Meanwhile, the television is still the most watched medium. With digital media coming into existence, TV is trying to maintain its own stature. It is an important tool of advertisement to create an instant impact on the general public. A good advertisement would surely attract the attention of the viewers and get the message communicated to them. And thus, more and more product manufacturers and advertising agencies are coming up with television advertisements which are telecast on television channels.

9.6 REPORTING A FASHION SHOW

Covering fashion shows is an important task that a fashion journalist has on his/her hand. The readers want to know not only about the designs on display but also what is in store for them for the future. Thus, a fashion journalist

professional needs to be thorough with the background of the designer or the brand putting up the fashion show, participating models and also the related technical aspects such as fabrics, colours, embellishments, silhouettes, cuts, drape, fall etc.

A journalist must report on the news fashion trends set by the designers. If the show displays clothes for the coming season, the journalist must take note of dominant colours, fabrics, styles etc on the basis of which the fashion journalists can forecast the trends which could be in vogue. In addition, one should read about what is happening on the runways in other fashion capitals in the world and compare the design and colours to make the story really interesting and informative. Reporting on fashion needs an eye for the creative aspect of it.

9.7 WRITING ON FASHION TRENDS

Writing for any beat needs lot of research and understanding of the subject. Same goes with the fashion journalist also, who needs to know about the fashion trends of the past, present and future. One's story should not be based on the interviews of a handful of big names in the field as trends in haute couture is different from the general fashion trends. It is important that the fashion journalist stays in touch with established fashion designers, manufacturers, distributors, merchandising teams of big retail stores. A reporter should also be well versed with the fashion trends across the globe. For example, if one is writing on trends in denims, he or she needs to talk about the past trends in the country, how it evolved with respect to the global scenario.

9.8 BASIC TERMINOLOGIES

Here, let us look at some of the basic terminologies being used in the fashion industry. A fashion reporter must be well aware about these terms for the smooth growth of his/her career.

1. **Haute Couture:** Exquisite garments made from high quality fabrics for specific customers.
2. **Design:** Plan employed in construction of a garment.
3. **Designer:** One who designs is a Designer.
4. **Style:** Physical techniques used in creating a garment.
5. **Fashion:** Style of clothing in vogue
6. **Studio:** Workroom of a Designer
7. **Ready to Wear (Pret a Porter):** Finished clothes made for large consumption.
8. **Silhouette:** Outline of a dress or fashion product.
9. **Hallmark:** Official mark on precious items.
10. **Packaging:** Presenting a product in a manner that it looks presentable and also protects from possible damages.

11. **Fashion Show:** An event put up a Designer to showcase his product through live models.
12. **Model:** Person or an object used to display designer creations.
13. **Modeling:** Presenting a designer creation by an individual.
14. **Mannequin:** A dummy to display fit clothing.
15. **Choreography:** Act of displaying garments using live models.
16. **Knitting:** Method by which thread or yarn is turned into cloth.
17. **Woven:** Cloth made by weaving.
18. **Fabrication:** Act of preparing garment or fashion product by cutting, sewing and other actions involved.
19. **Label:** A piece printed or attached to a fashion product providing information about materials used, manufacturer and price.
20. **Boutique:** A small shop housing designer items for display and sale.
21. **Retail:** Sale of fashion products through small outlets directly to customers.
22. **Visual Merchandising:** Refers to style of presentation of fashion products in retail outlets to entice customers.
23. **Window Dressing:** Placing fashion products elegantly in windows of a retail outlet.
24. **Embellishment:** Decoration on exteriors of a garment.
25. **Merchandising:** Promotion and sale of a garment.
26. **Hi-Fashion:** Trend setting styles.
27. **Catwalk:** Act of presenting objects before live audience through walks on ramps by live models.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. In what areas can we find story ideas in fashion journalism?

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9.9 LIFESTYLE : OTHER AREAS

In addition to the fashion and lifestyle products discussed above in detail, there are many other areas also which are linked with the modern life. These include:

9.9.1 Yoga and Fitness

With more and more people becoming health conscious, Yoga has become part of the daily routine in many Indian families. Initially restricted to few

health-conscious households, now more people are practicing yoga as a part of their lifestyle. Print, Electronic and Digital media are now focusing on the importance of Yoga on almost daily basis. Several expert articles are included into media now a days. Yoga practitioners are spread across the globe and many products have been especially manufactured to cater to their needs which include specially designed clothes, mats etc. Yoga Clubs where people come to learn and practice it, have become popular across the country.

9.9.2 Travel and Food

Though India has a long tradition of traveling to temples situated in remotest parts of the country, people in general are now traveling to cities and places that are located in lap of nature. Travel blogging has become very popular, with a lot of people, not journalist but commoners, have started minute-to-minute blogging. Many travelers look for places which are not easily accessible and offer thrill and adventure. Travel blogging helps you plan your travel goals and aspirations. This is a career prospect for the budding journalists. Many tour and traveling companies have come to existence which facilitate hassle free journey and stay, as also offer discounts. A number of magazines are in circulation and many books have been published giving information on tourist places and travel tips.

Writing about food is not new. People have been doing that from ages. Exclusive TV channels providing content on food are also liked by many. Just like travel blogging, food blogging is a newly growing and developing field. Information about good food outlets help people sort their preferences. People in general have become choosy about the kind of food and the place of dining. Good restaurants offering pleasant ambience and tasty foods have sprung up across cities in the country which are thronged by many including those from middle class. While there are few magazines that are devoted solely to foods, many books published on the topic have turned out to be bestsellers. Also, today a new concept of sharing recipes has cropped up, especially after COVID lockdown in the year 2020. Social media has given a platform to the commoners to post and share their recipies online, thereby contributing in the pool of knowledge.

9.9.3 Books

Writing about books has been in trend from a long time. Books are part of everyday life for a big section of people. They say, 'When you open a book, you open a new world.' writing about book is a dedicated section for avid readers, who want to know about newly launched books, book reviews etc. We have had books since centuries and without them knowledge of our past ancestors, cultures and civilizations would not have been possible. Covering of book fairs organized in a particular city is also one aspect of reporting on books.

9.10 FILM, TV AND WEB SERIES

Film journalism is a well-established field. Be it print media or television or news websites, film related content finds ample space everywhere. Film reviews, discussions of new films, controversies related to films, and the lives

of film actors, find a considerable amount of space in the news media. There is a large amount of film-related content available in newspaper supplements. Television news channels also broadcast dedicated shows on films. Apart from films, now television serials and web series are also getting a lot of space in the news media. There are plenty of reporting opportunities available in these fields.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. How does the news media cover films ?

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9.10 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we discussed in detail about journalism related to fashion, lifestyle and films. We first talked about the different dimensions of fashion journalism, then briefly discussed the importance other lifestyle related areas like Yoga, fitness, travel, food and books are getting in the media. At the end, a brief discussion was also held on film journalism.

9.11 FURTHER READINGS

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Hannelare Eberle (2008) Clothing Technology: From Fibre to Fashion, Verlag Europa-Lehrmittel Noun, Haan, Germany

9.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1: Please refer to 9.3.2

Check Your Progress 2: Please refer to 9.5

Check Your Progress 3: Please refer to 9.10

UNIT 10 REPORTING HEALTH AND EDUCATION

Structure

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10.0 INTRODUCTION

Health stories have become a topic of interest among common people. With kind of diseases breaking in, health has become a topic of utmost importance for almost everyone. However, health is a complex beat to cover as it requires a delicate balance of knowledge, research and sensitivity. Since, the stories covered under this beat are directly related with the well-being of a person, there is no scope of errors in the facts included in the articles.

In this unit we shall learn about the basics of health reporting and the contemporary scenario of health reporting in the country. We shall also discuss the various aspects of reporting health, the many types of health reporting and the interlinking of various issues to health. We shall also try to understand some basic medical terms that are commonly used in day to day lives and are essential for reporter's knowledge while doing health news coverage. Through this unit we shall also touch upon some of the common mistakes committed by the beat reporter while reporting health.

The second focus of this unit is education reporting. We all know that education is one of the main pillars of human society. This unit covers important aspects of education beat or reporting.

10.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completing this unit you will be able to:

- understand the basic aspects and significance of health and education reporting;
- identify the challenges faced by health and education reporters and also the opportunities at hand; and
- explain the format and essentials of reporting health and education stories in a responsible, informed and balanced manner.

10.2 HEALTH REPORTING

Now we shall discuss different aspects of health reporting.

10.2.1 Basics of Health Reporting

Health reporting might look like a simple thing to do. But looking at it from a closer perspective reveals the vastness and depth of this subject. The health related news doesn't only effect the public but also the medical professionals, therefore, it has a greater responsibility. The health beat also closely revolves around the government and helps them make policies from the information they receive from the stories covered by media professionals. So, the information being given has to be precise, correct and reliable. There is very little scope of carelessness while reporting health. There is a vast amount of health related information in public domain and not all of it is reliable. It is the duty of a health reporter to be both sensitive and objective in approach and to never give in to the temptation of sensationalism.

There are various areas of health reporting such as - public and community health, disease outbreaks, health policy, business, health infrastructure, corruption and ethical matters, consumer health, drugs and diseases, factors affecting health, etc.

10.2.2 Health Reporting in India

With a population of over 1.4 billion people, widespread poverty and lack of infrastructure, health related issues/ problems are common and widespread in India. Health reporting is not just an important part of the Indian journalism but its challenging too. Several experts believe that health reporting in the country is not up to the mark. One reason can be the tussle of TRPs in TV news channels where journalists face time constrain and file stories without much of research. Another reason for it is the lack of a comprehensive understanding of the issues which prevents them from covering the news in a relevant manner.

News stories/articles filed without proper research might lead to dissemination of wrong information. Health stories published without much research can inevitably have a poor impact on the minds of people. The skill and knowledge gaps and lack of objectivity are plaguing health journalism in India. It has been observed that health in spite of its immense significance doesn't seem to be a priority beat for journalists in India. However, big media

houses do have a well-trained and specialized journalists for reporting health stories. Mostly it is taken up when a pressing public health issue like a disease outbreak comes to the fore. The importance of research for health reporting was specifically felt with the outbreak of corona virus in the year 2020. Almost all newspapers, news channels and even the digital news portals were regressively posting the stories/articles about this new virus. But, the dissemination of wrong and misleading information was also common. This is when it was felt that health reporting in India needs to develop as a full-fledged beat.

10.2.3 Health Reporting: Things to Know

Reporting health cannot be approached casually. In fact it needs proper understanding of the subject, without which it is impossible for any reporter to convert the information into an easy form for laymen audience. The reproduction of information has to be in palatable form which is easy to grasp for readers who have no or little understanding of health related issues.

A reporter is expected to have a clear understanding of the functioning of the health set up. S/he must also acquaint himself/herself with the various terms and procedures that are mentioned or used commonly. One should be careful not to take anything for granted and make sure to double check the information provided to you.

10.2.4 Basic Health Related Terms Useful in Health Beat

Here we shall discuss some basic health related terms useful in health reporting. Knowing these terms will help you in health journalism.

1. **Acute-** In medical context, this means “of severe, sudden but short duration”
2. **AIDS-** Acquired Immuno Deficiency Syndrome
3. **Allergy-** Adverse reaction to a foreign substance in the form of sneezing, rash, bronchitis, fever etc.
4. **Anaemia-** Decrease in concentration of red blood cells / haemoglobin. Causes weakness and paleness
5. **Antibiotic-** Drug group that kills bacteria
6. **Appendicitis-** Inflammation of the appendix
7. **Asthma-** Lung condition characterised by difficulty in breathing, coughing and wheezing
8. **BCG-** Bacillus Calmette Guerin- vaccination for Tuberculosis
9. **Bronchi/ Bronchial-** Connecting passageway to lungs
10. **Bronchitis-** Inflammation of bronchi
11. **Buccal cavity-** Mouth cavity
12. **Chronic-** Severe and of long duration. As opposed to acute
13. **Cognition-** More complex mental functioning like insight, memory, intelligence, judgement
14. **Coma-** a persistent unconscious state

15. **CPR-** Cardio Pulmonary Resuscitation – Combined resuscitation of the lungs and heart
16. **Dementia-** Total or partial loss of personality and other mental functions (no psychosis)
17. **Dermatitis-** Inflammation of skin (due to various reasons)
18. **Diabetes-** Condition of having persistent high blood sugar.
19. **ECG-** Electrocardiogram. Electronic recording of the activity of heart to detect abnormalities
20. **Epilepsy-** Convulsions due to abnormal electrical discharges in the brain
21. **Fracture-** Breaking of bone
22. **Gastritis-** Inflammation of stomach lining
23. **Haematuria:** Blood in Urine
24. **Haemoglobin:** Iron containing protein found in red blood cells. Carries Oxygen to the cells
25. **Haemorrhage:** Loss of blood from body. Could be internal or external
26. **Heart Attack:** Acute onset of disturbance of heartbeat rhythm
27. **Hepatitis:** Liver inflammation due to alcohol consumption or viral infection
28. **HIV (Human Immunodeficiency Virus)-** Virus which infect the immune system and impedes its functioning
29. **Hypertension-** Blood Pressure above normal
30. **Hypothermia:** Below normal body temperature which may be life threatening
31. **Inflammation-** Body's reaction to injury or infection. Sign include localised redness, heat, tenderness and swelling
32. **Insomnia-** Inability to sleep
33. **Insulin-** Hormone produced by pancreas to convert sugar into energy. Lacking or low in diabetics
34. **Jaundice-** Yellow discolouration of skin and eyes due to liver disease
35. **Meningitis-** Inflammation of the three protective layers of the brain, the meninges
36. **Nausea-** Unpleasant feeling in the stomach region
37. **Paralysis:** Lack of movement in any part of the body due to nerve damage
38. **Pneumonia:** Infection of the lung tissue
39. **Pulmonary:** Pertaining to the lung or bronchial system
40. **Tetanus-** Bacterial infection beginning from wound which have not been cleaned properly. Can cause paralysis
41. **Tuberculosis (TB)-** Bacterial infection of the lungs or kidneys.
42. **Urological-** Pertaining to the bladder, kidney or urinary system

43. Virus- An infective particle which requires host cells to reproduce. Cannot be destroyed by anti-biotics

10.2.5 Different Areas of Health Reporting

Health reporting covers various areas of health sector. Now we'll discuss some of important areas.

Reporting on 'Disease Outbreaks'

Outbreak of disease is the most common form of health reporting in the Indian scenario. Outbreak of an disease causes an atmosphere of anxiety and panic, which results in rise of interest for such stories among the public. While on one hand such stories can be popularized easily, it is the responsibility of the reporter to check for any element of sensationalism or drama in the stories he/she is filing. Disease outbreaks especially during the initial period make important news because there is a general sense of eagerness among the public to gather maximum information. In case the disease is new or lesser known, the research aspect also comes into play and gives the journalists a good opportunity to make the coverage comprehensive and informative. News related to disease outbreaks must be reported in a very responsible manner that the facts provided are not ambiguous or incorrect. It should be articulated considering both scientific and social perspective.

Things to keep in mind while reporting disease outbreaks:

- Information provided should be factually correct and precise.
- Information should not have any ambiguity.
- Important questions to ask during the initial stages of disease include
 - What are the major symptoms of the disease?
 - When is it important to see a doctor?
 - What is the nature of the disease-causing pathogen?
 - How is the pathogen being transmitted?
 - Who is at risk?
 - What are the major precautions to be taken?
 - What are the short term and long-term effects of the disease?
 - What are the environmental factors affecting the outbreak?
 - Dispelling of myths.
 - line of treatment.
- The answers to these questions must be sought through relevant and reliable sources. Medical experts from recognised institutions, renowned medical practitioners, drug and vaccine companies, scientists, health workers can be contacted to provide genuine and precise information.
- The impact of disease outbreak can be different in different areas based on the environmental factors. Therefore, the journalist must provide its readers a story with a wider perspective.
- The news story filed should be objective in nature. In case of the

outbreak of new disease, the journalist is advised not give predictions based on the assumptions as it might create confusion and a situation of panic among the readers.

- Precautionary measures should be repeatedly stressed.
- Post the outbreak, there should be the time for retrospection and lessons learnt.

Reporting on Lifestyle Diseases

To go by definition, lifestyle disease is any medical disorder which are caused by poor lifestyle practices such as diet, physical activity etc. A prime example of lifestyle disease is diabetes along with obesity etc. In past several years it has been observed that there is a steep rise in lifestyle disease among the Indian population. The way of life has changed considerably and the effect on health has begun to show. Smoking, drinking, drug abuse, sedentary lifestyle, unhealthy eating are some of the major causes of lifestyle diseases. Asthma, stroke, depression, osteoporosis are other diseases which can be categorised as lifestyle diseases. Diseases due to air pollution have also become important lately. Lifestyle diseases hold relevance in the modern day for the enormous implications they have. Different categories of lifestyle diseases are affecting different economic and social strata of the society. Since lifestyle diseases have struck a huge audience, more and more people are interested in reading news stories related to it. Reporting lifestyle diseases will require the journalist to broaden his/her horizon and look at the interlinked multidimensional aspects.

Also, these diseases are huge burden on economy and also drain the demographic dividend. When reporting lifestyle disease, there must be a clear stress on the causative factors, so as to raise awareness among people and to help them make better and healthier life choices.

Reporting on Mental Health

Mental health and well-being is a subject that is gathering prominence in the field of health reporting and otherwise. With heavy penetration of internet in the society and change in social structures, several experts and organisations have raised concerns about the mental health and well-being of people. Now a days common public is becoming increasingly aware and sensitive about the broad spectrum of mental illness and their effects on the suffering individual. Gradually the stigma has also begun to recede, credit for which can be given to the positive stories being published by the media.

When reporting on a mental health condition, a journalist must ensure that all the facts are checked and verified properly as such stories are of greater relevance to the society. Also, the news story should be written with a lot of sensitivity and consideration, specially if you are quoting a real-life example. It is best to seek the help of a qualified medical professional rather than relying on hearsay. Using correct language and appropriate words is also important. Words like 'mentally ill', 'abuse', and 'suffering' should be avoided. The story must be framed in such a way as to remove the stigma around the mental illness.

Some common Mental Health Related terms:

1. **Addiction** is a condition that causes the person to use a substance compulsively despite harmful consequences.
2. **Alcohol and substance use disorders** refer to the overuse of alcohol or drugs leading to effects that are detrimental to the individual's physical and mental health, or the welfare of others
3. **Autism** spectrum disorders are a range of complex developmental disorders that can cause problems with thinking, feeling, language and the ability to relate to others
4. **Bipolar disorder**, also commonly known as manic depression, is a brain disorder that causes shifts in a person's mood, energy and ability to function
5. **Depression** is a common and serious medical illness that causes feelings of sadness and/or a loss of interest in activities once enjoyed; it can lead to a variety of emotional and physical problems
6. **Obsessive Compulsive Disorder (OCD)** is an anxiety disorder in which people have recurring, unwanted thoughts, ideas or sensations (obsessions) that make them feel driven to do something repetitively (compulsions)
7. **Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)** is a psychiatric disorder that can occur in people who have experienced or witnessed a traumatic event such as a natural disaster, a serious accident, a terrorist act, war/combat, rape or other violent personal assault.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. List down the important things one should keep in mind while reporting disease outbreaks?

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2. What are the different areas of health reporting ?

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10.2.6 Challenges to Health Reporters

The reporters on health beat face many challenges. These are as follows:

To have in-depth understanding of the issues: Health journalism requires proper knowledge and understanding of the subject. Since, this reporting is

directly related to the well-being of the audiences/readers, it is important that the journalist does in-depth research of the subjected he is reporting on. Whether a mental health story or about health implications related to sexual abuse, the reporter must research on the topic before filing the copy. Until s/he understands the subject completely, s/he will not be able to simplify it to a palatable form for the reader. On the other hand, reporters work under the pressure of filing stories within the deadlines. Sometimes it may make difficult situation for adequate research.

Lack of Data: At times, there can be a dearth of adequate data on a particular health related topic, especially in case of a novel disease outbreak. In such situations the journalist might not have enough data or researches to refer to for reporting. Another aspect to it is the time constraint. The pressure to file the story does not give the reporter enough time to do the research himself. Paucity of correct data greatly impedes the work of a reporter. Without reliable data, it is difficult to lend credibility to the story.

Non-cooperative Officials: Another hindrance to effective health reporting occurs when officials in the government or hospitals are sometimes apprehensive of sharing facts with reporters or allowing them access to data. Insufficient facts because of non-cooperative officials may also prove to be a hindrance in reporting.

Hesitation of patients: There might be a general perception that reporters disregard the privacy of the patients and may divulge details which may jeopardize the image of the individual in public. However, through real life examples journalist need to be sensitive in such cases and gradually develop a rapport with the patients and their families. It would be easier for the patients to talk if they trust the reporter.

10.2.7 Health Reporting: Things to Keep in Mind

While reporting for Health Beat, we must keep the following in mind. This will improve the reporting quality.

1. As we have discussed so far, health related stories are read with great interest among the public. Therefore, a reporter must remember that his/her story is information based. This would help not just the readers but also the health care providers in making sensible and optimal treatment choices. They should be able to bridge the communication gap between the doctor and patient.
2. Health stories should have an element of resonance. Stories that focus on people, help establish a strong audience connect. However, it is important that the credibility of the report is maintained, which means that it should not stick to just one person's opinion and can be generalized.
3. It is important to focus on the human angle of the questions asked and not just on the facts.
4. A health story should be written with lot of empathy and sensitiveness.

5. Double check the facts. Government data alone should not be the source of story. Ground reality may be different and must be verified before publishing the story.
6. Evidence based coverage adds credibility to the story.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. List three things that we should keep in mind while doing health reporting.

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10.3 EDUCATION REPORTING

Just like health reporting, education reporting is also an important beat that contain stories of human interest. Education beat encompasses within it a wide spectrum of subjects. Primary education, secondary education, college education, vocational education, special education, government policies on education, all of these would fall under the wide umbrella of education. The inclusion of areas such as home schooling, non-profit organisations working for education, education reform and education technology has led to the broadening of this field. Education has social and economic and even political implications and hence requires due attention from reporters and journalists. It is the prime responsibility of education reporters to inform the public about all aspects of education and at all levels, local, state, national and international. Therefore, education reporting needs to be done in a responsible, informed and balanced manner with adequate facts and statistics to back up the arguments that the reporter provides.

10.3.1 Suitable News Sources

Best reliable sources to gather information related to education are education professionals. News releases, conferences on education and public notices are also considered as news sources. For political and policy aspects, usually the government agencies at state or central level are contacted. For social aspects, non-profit organisations and institutions particularly dedicated to education may prove to be worthy news sources. Reporters today, also keep a tab on social media to get new ideas and feel the pulse of the public about a certain issue. They can also get in touch with students or parents to get feedback, opinions and suggestions. Academic researchers and think tanks can also provide very valuable insight into education and related issues. Apart from being sources news, they can also lead to new story ideas.

10.3.2 Requisites of Education Reporting

Education reporting demands patience and discipline among the reporters working on the beat. A reporting is expected to be able to perceive an issue

from different points of views. The reporter should also be able to write a balanced story. Just like health reporting, education reporting also requires a lot of research to be done before filing the final story. To authenticate the story, the reporter can include some facts and statistics, like literacy rates, graduation rates, dropout rates, teacher retention and vacancy rates. Sometimes comparison between these rates can bring forth significant trends and present a clear picture of the scenario. It is also necessary to pay attention to the details behind the data. For example, one cannot simply compare dropout or attendance rates between all schools without taking into account aspects like social background, economic status and demographics. A well balanced story is always likeable among the readers/audiences.

10.3.3 Writing a Story on Education

Since news on education caters to a large audience, it needs to be well researched, contain authentic facts, and should include a human angle as well. The five Ws- Who, What, Where, When, Why, must always be answered wherever possible. The news value and the inverted pyramid model must be kept in mind. The story should always be fair, balanced, concise and correct without elements of sensationalism. An education news story should be such that it answers all the queries of its audience, which means it should not leave too many open- ended questions for the readers. Vague terms, jargons, statements and phrases must be avoided. The story must be objective in nature and should be free from any kind of biases. Opinions of all concerned parties must be duly included in the story. Any claim must always be supported by evidence and figures.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your answer

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the suitable news sources for education reporting ?

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10.3.4 Areas for News Stories

The following are the major trends in education, each of which can lead to stories to be covered from different angles. Each of these heads is an issue that has challenges continually faced by the education system of the country. You may use these as the subjects of your education stories.

1. The Performance Gap
2. The School/College Choice and Ranking
3. Early Childhood Education
4. Standards and Testing
5. Teacher Evaluation and Training
6. Reservation in Education

7. Educational Infrastructure
8. Role of Non-profit organizations
9. Digital Learning
10. Higher Education
11. Education related mental stress

10.3.5 Challenges

One of the major challenges faced by the education reporters is the privacy concerns, as many institutes/colleges/university/schools don't like to disclose their policies with media. This prevents the reporters from being able to put up the facts in front of the public. In order to construct a better story, a journalist can invest in maintaining good repo with the teachers and school management. This will help him quote some real life examples.

The second challenge is pursuing 'In-depth coverage'. The time constraint and constant pressure makes the reporter unable to give ample time for research. This can compromise on the quality of story as certain angles may not be fully researched.

The third challenge faced by an education journalist is 'Expertise'. Though the reporters in their course of experience may gain enough knowledge, subject matter expertise may often be lacking. This will prevent the reporter from gaining a comprehensive understanding of the issue herself/himself, which will be reflected in the story.

10.3.6 Future of Education Reporting

The education beat is an evergreen reporting beat, importance of which will never fade. In a developing country like India, education is the subject of importance. However, from the journalistic point of view it is not given as much importance as political news. The education beat needs to firmly stand its ground to survive and subsequently has to reinvent itself to maintain connect with the news consumer. Education is a very important part of nation building and needs to be given the importance it deserves by the media.

With new type of professional courses venturing into the country, education beat is striving to carve a niche in all possible avenues. The Government of India has recently launched and implemented the New Education Policy (NEP-2020), which seeks to restructure school curricular and pedagogy and to achieve foundational literacy and numeracy in primary schools. Apart from the primary education, the NEP also focuses on the encouraging 'high performance' of Indian Universities with respect to the higher education. These changes in the current scenario makes the education reporting challenging. However, with challenges also comes new opportunities and scope. The journalists must keep up with the change in the education policy. What happens at policy level will eventually trickle down to local level, so even when a reporter is covering local news on education, it has national importance. The reporter needs to be innovative with their news stories to make maximum impact on people's mind.

10.4 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed two important reporting beats - health and education. Both of them relate to the society at large and have a direct bearing on the community. Health reporting stresses on the nature, need and various aspects of health to be focused on. The learner was acquainted with the basic health terminology. Education reporting was the second part of the unit which highlighted the need and importance of this beat, identification of news sources, requisites and challenges of education reporting. Trends and future of education reporting were also discussed.

10.5 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

<http://indianexpress.com/article/india/india-news-india/unicef-bats-for-better-health-reporting-in-india-2771251/>

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<https://www.psychiatry.org/newsroom/reporting-on-mental-health-conditions>

<http://www.sciencemediacentre.co.nz/guidelines-for-science-health-reporting/>

<http://www.ewa.org/sites/main/files/file-attachments/2016-05-10-state-of-beat-report.pdf>

<http://educationnext.org/the-future-of-education-journalism/>

10.6 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Please refer to 10.2.5
2. Please refer to 10.2.5

Check Your Progress 2

1. Please refer to 10.2.7

Check Your Progress 3

1. Please refer to 10.3.1

